

‘How much will it amount to, to make your bandits all drunk with wine, and to satisfy them with gold?’

‘Oh, monsieur, what an expression! Oh! monsieur, if they heard you! some of them are very susceptible.’

‘I mean to say they must be brought to the point where they cannot tell the heavens from the earth; for I shall to-morrow contend with the king; and when I fight I mean to conquer—please to understand.’

‘It shall be done, monsieur. Give me your other ideas.’

‘That is your business.’

‘Then give me your purse.’

‘Gourville, count a hundred thousand livres for the Abbé.’

‘Good! and spare nothing, did you not say?’

‘Nothing.’

‘That is well.’

‘Monseigneur,’ objected Gourville, ‘if this should be known, we should lose our heads.’

‘Eh! Gourville,’ replied Fouquet, purple with anger, ‘you excite my pity. Speak for yourself, if you please. My head does not shake in that manner upon my shoulders. Now, Abbé, is everything arranged?’

‘Everything.’

‘At two o’clock to-morrow.’

‘At twelve, because it will be necessary to prepare our auxiliaries in a secret manner.’

‘That is true; do not spare the wine of the cabaretier.’

‘I will spare neither his wine nor his house,’ replied the Abbé, with a sneering laugh. ‘I have my plan, I tell you; leave me to set it in operation, and you shall see.’

‘Where shall you be yourself?’

‘Everywhere, nowhere.’

‘And how shall I receive information?’

‘By a courier whose horse shall be kept in the very same garden of your friend. A propos, the name of your friend?’

Fouquet looked again at Gourville. The latter came to the succor of his master, saying, [‘The name is of no importance.’

Fouquet continued, ‘Accompany] monsieur l’Abbé, for several reasons, but the house is easily to be known—the “Image-de-Notre-Dame” in the front, a garden, the only one in the quarter, behind.’¹

‘Good, good! I will go and give notice to my soldiers.’

‘Accompany him, Gourville,’ said Fouquet, ‘and count him down the money. One moment, Abbé—one moment, Gourville—what name will be given to this carrying off?’

‘A very natural one, monsieur—the Riot.’

‘The riot on account of what? For, if ever the people of Paris are disposed to pay their court to the king, it is when he hangs financiers.’

‘I will manage that,’ said the Abbé.

‘Yes; but you may manage it badly, and people will guess.’

‘Not at all,—not at all. I have another idea.’

‘What is that?’

‘My men shall cry out, “Colbert, vive Colbert!” and shall throw themselves upon the prisoners as if they would tear them in pieces, and shall force them from the gibbets, as too mild a punishment.’

‘Ah! that is an idea,’ said Gourville. ‘Peste! monsieur l’Abbé, what an imagination you have!’

‘Monsieur, we are worthy of our family,’ replied the Abbé, proudly.

‘Strange fellow,’ murmured Fouquet. Then he added, ‘That is ingenious. Carry it out, but shed no blood.’

Gourville and the Abbé set off together, with their heads full of the meditated riot. The superintendent laid himself down upon some cushions, half valiant with respect to the sinister projects of the morrow, half dreaming of love.

¹The text in the print copy is corrupt at this point. The suggested reading, in brackets, is by John Bursey.

‘Well?’

‘There will then be, to-morrow, on the Place de Grève, which I choose as my battle-field, ten thousand auxiliaries to my hundred and twenty men. The attack commenced by the latter, the others will finish it.’

‘That all appears feasible. But what will be done with regard to the prisoners upon the Place de Grève?’

‘This: they must be thrust into some house—that will make a siege necessary to get them out again. And stop! here is another idea, more sublime still: certain houses have two issues—one upon the Place, and the other into the Rue de la Morrellerie, or la Yannerie, or la Tixeranderie. The prisoners entering by one door will go out at another.’

‘Yes; but fix upon something positive.’

‘I am seeking to do so.’

‘And I,’ cried Fouquet, ‘I have found it. Listen to what has occurred to me at this moment.’

‘I am listening.’

Fouquet made a sign to Gourville, who appeared to understand. ‘One of my friends lends me sometimes the keys of a house which he rents, Rue Baudoyer, the spacious gardens of which extend behind a certain house on the Place de Grève.’

‘That is the place for us,’ said the Abbé. ‘What house?’

‘A cabaret, pretty well frequented, whose sign represents the image of Notre Dame.’

‘I know it,’ said the Abbé.

‘This cabaret has windows opening upon the Place, a place of exit into the court, which must abut upon the gardens of my friend by a door of communication.’

‘Good!’ said the Abbé.

‘Enter by the cabaret, take the prisoners in; defend the door while you enable them to fly by the garden and the Place Baudoyer.’

‘That is all plain. Monsieur, you would make an excellent general, like monsieur le prince.’

‘Have you understood me?’

‘Perfectly well.’

'It will not be the first time such a thing has happened to them, monseigneur.'

'That is well: but would these bandits attack an armed force?'

'They are used to that.'

'Then get your hundred and twenty men together, Abbé.'

'Directly. But where?'

'On the road to Vincennes, to-morrow, at two o'clock precisely.'

'To carry off Lyodot and D'Eymeris? There will be blows to be got!'

'A number, no doubt; are you afraid?'

'Not for myself, but for you.'

'Your men will know, then, what they have to do?'

'They are too intelligent not to guess it. Now, a minister who gets up a riot against his king—exposes himself—'

'Of what importance is that to you, I pray? Besides, if I fall, you fall with me.'

'It would then be more prudent, monsieur, not to stir in the affair, and leave the king to take this little satisfaction.'

'Think well of this, Abbé, Lyodot and D'Eymeris at Vincennes are a prelude of ruin for my house. I repeat it—I arrested, you will be imprisoned—I imprisoned, you will be exiled.'

'Monsieur, I am at your orders; have you any to give me?'

'What I told you—I wish that, to-morrow, the two financiers of whom they mean to make victims, whilst there remain so many criminals unpunished, should be snatched from the fury of my enemies. Take your measures accordingly. Is it possible?'

'It is possible.'

'Describe your plan.'

'It is of rich simplicity. The ordinary guard at executions consists of twelve archers.'

'There will be a hundred to-morrow.'

'I reckon so. I even say more—there will be two hundred.'

'Then your hundred and twenty men will not be enough.'

'Pardon me. In every crowd composed of a hundred thousand spectators, there are ten thousand bandits or cut-purses—only they dare not take the initiative.'

Chapter LXI

The Cabaret of the Image-de-Notre-Dame



AT two o'clock the next day fifty thousand spectators had taken their position upon the Place, around the two gibbets which had been elevated between the Quai de la Grève and the Quai Pelletier; one close to the other, with their backs to the embankment of the river. In the morning also, all the sworn criers of the good city of Paris had traversed the quarters of the city, particularly the halles and the faubourgs, announcing with their hoarse and indefatigable voices the great justice done by the king upon two speculators, two thieves, devoursers of the people. And these people, whose interests were so warmly looked after, in order not to fail in respect for their king, quitted shops, stalls, and ateliers, to go and evince a little gratitude to Louis XIV, absolutely like invited guests, who feared to commit an impoliteness in not repairing to the house of him who had invited them. According to the tenor of the sentence, which the criers read aloud and incorrectly, two farmers of the revenues, monopolists of money, dilapidators of the royal provisions, extortioners, and forgers, were about to undergo capital punishment on the Place de Grève, with their names blazoned over their heads, according to their sentence. As to those names, the sentence made no mention of them. The curiosity of the Parisians was at its height, and, as we have said, an immense crowd waited with feverish impatience the hour fixed for the execution. The news had already spread that the prisoners, transferred to the château of Vincennes, would be conducted from that prison to the Place de Grève. Consequently, the faubourg and the Rue Saint Antoine were crowded; for the population of Paris in those days of

great executions was divided into two categories: those who came to see the condemned pass—these were of timid and mild hearts, but philosophically curious—and those who wished to see the condemned die—these had hearts that hungered for sensation. On this day M. d'Aragnan received his last instructions from the king, and made his adieus to his friends, the number of whom was, at the moment, reduced to Planchet, then he traced the plan of his day, as every busy man whose moments are counted ought to do, because he appreciates their importance.

'My departure is to be,' said he, 'at break of day, three o'clock in the morning; I have then fifteen hours before me. Take from them the six hours of sleep which are indispensable for me—six; one hour for repasts—seven; one hour for a farewell visit to Athos—eight; two hours for chance circumstances—total, ten. There are then five hours left. One hour to get my money,—that is, to have payment refused by M. Fouquet; another hour to go and receive my money of M. Colbert, together with his questions and grimaces; one hour to look over my clothes and arms, and get my boots cleaned. I still have two hours left. Mordious! how rich I am.' And so saying, D'Aragnan felt a strange joy, a joy of youth, a perfume of those great and happy years of former times mount into his brain and intoxicate him. 'During these two hours I will go,' said the musketeer, 'and take my quarter's rent of the Image-de-Notre-Dame. That will be pleasant. Three hundred and seventy-five livres! Mordious! but that is astonishing! If the poor man who has but one livre in his pocket, found a livre and twelve deniers, that would be justice, that would be excellent; but never does such a godsend fall to the lot of the poor man. The rich man, on the contrary, makes himself revenue with his money, which he does not even touch. Here are three hundred and seventy-five livres which fall to me from heaven. I will go then to the Image-de-Notre-Dame, and drink a glass of Spanish wine with my tenant, which he cannot fail to offer me. But order must be observed, Monsieur d'Aragnan, order must be observed! Let us organize our time, then, and distribute the employment of it! Art. 1st, Athos; Art. 2d, the Image-de-Notre-Dame; Art. 3rd, M. Fouquet; Art. 4th, M. Colbert; Art. 5th, supper; Art. 6th, clothes, boots, horse, portmanteau; Art. 7th and last, sleep.'

In consequence of this arrangement, D'Aragnan went straight to the Comte de la Fère, to whom, modestly and ingeniously, he related a part of his fortu-

Chapter LX

Plan of Battle



HE night was already far advanced when the Abbé Fouquet joined his brother. Gourville had accompanied him. These three men, pale with dread of future events, resembled less three powers of the day than three conspirators, united by one single thought of violence. Fouquet walked for a long time, with his eyes fixed upon the floor, striking his hands one against the other. At length, taking courage, in the midst of a deep sigh: 'Abbé,' said he, 'you were speaking to me only to-day of certain people you maintain.'

'Yes, monsieur,' replied the Abbé.

'Tell me precisely who are these people.' The Abbé hesitated.

'Comel! no fear, I am not threatening; no romancing, for I am not joking.'

'Since you demand the truth, monseigneur, here it is:—I have a hundred and twenty friends or companions of pleasure, who are sworn to me as the thief is to the gallows.'

'And you think you can depend on them?'

'Entirely.'

'And you will not compromise yourself?'

'I will not even make my appearance.'

'Are they men of resolution?'

'They would burn Paris, if I promised them they should not be burnt in turn.'

'The thing I ask of you, Abbé,' said Fouquet, wiping the sweat which fell from his brow, 'is to throw your hundred and twenty men upon the people I will point out to you, at a certain moment given—is it possible?'

hand, was profuse in his attentions. 'What an honour for me, monseigneur,' said he.

'One word, monsieur le gouverneur, will you take the trouble to get into my carriage?' The officer placed himself opposite Fouquet in the coach.

'Monsieur,' said Fouquet, 'I have a service to ask of you.'

'Speak, monseigneur.'

'A service that will be compromising for you, monsieur, but which will assure to you forever my protection and my friendship.'

'Were it to cast myself into the fire for you, monseigneur, I would do it.'

'That is well,' said Fouquet; 'what I require is much more simple.'

'That being so, monseigneur, what is it?'

'To conduct me to the chamber of Messieurs Lyodot and D'Eymerys.'

'Will monseigneur have the kindness to say for what purpose?'

'I will tell you that in their presence, monsieur, at the same time that I will give you ample means of palliating this escape.'

'Escape! Why, then, monseigneur does not know?'

'What?'

'That Messieurs Lyodot and D'Eymerys are no longer here.'

'Since when?' cried Fouquet, in great agitation.

'About a quarter of an hour.'

'Whither have they gone, then?'

'To Vincennes—to the donjon.'

'Who took them from here?'

'An order from the king.'

'Oh! woe! woe!' exclaimed Fouquet, striking his forehead. 'Woe!' and without saying a single word more to the governor, he threw himself back into his carriage, despair in his heart, and death on his countenance.

'Well!' said Pelisson, with great anxiety.

'Our friends are lost. Colbert is conveying them to the donjon. They crossed our path under the arcade Saint-Jean.'

Pelisson, struck as by a thunderbolt, made no reply. With a single reproach he would have killed his master. 'Where is monseigneur going?' said the footman.

'Home—to Paris. You, Pelisson, return to Saint-Mande, and bring the Abbé Fouquet to me within an hour. Begone!'

nate adventures. Athos had not been without uneasiness on the subject of D'Aragnan's visit to the king; but few words sufficed for an explanation of that. Athos divined that Louis had charged D'Aragnan with some important mission, and did not even make an effort to draw the secret from him. He only recommended him to take care of himself, and offered discreetly to accompany him if that were desirable.

'But, my dear friend,' said D'Aragnan, 'I am going nowhere.'

'What! you come and bid me adieu, and are going nowhere?'

'Oh! yes, yes,' replied D'Aragnan, colouring a little, 'I am going to make an acquisition.'

'That is quite another thing. Then I change my formula. Instead of "Do not get yourself killed," I will say,—"Do not get yourself robbed."'

'My friend, I will inform you if I set eyes on any property that pleases me, and shall expect you will favour me with your opinion.'

'Yes, yes,' said Athos, too delicate to permit himself even the consolation of a smile. Raoul imitated the paternal reserve. But D'Aragnan thought it would appear too mysterious to leave his friends under a pretense, without even telling them the route he was about to take.

'I have chosen Le Mans,' said he to Athos. 'It is a good country?'

'Excellent, my friend,' replied the count, without making him observe that Le Mans was in the same directions as La Touraine, and that by waiting two days, at most, he might travel with a friend. But D'Aragnan, more embarrassed than the count, dug, at every explanation, deeper into the mud, into which he sank by degrees. 'I shall set out to-morrow at daybreak,' said he at last. 'Till that time, will you come with me, Raoul?'

'Yes, monsieur le chevalier,' said the young man, 'if monsieur le comte does not want me.'

'No, Raoul; I am to have an audience to-day of Monsieur, the king's brother; that is all I have to do.'

Raoul asked Grimaud for his sword, which the old man brought him immediately. 'Now then,' added D'Aragnan, opening his arms to Athos, 'adieu, my dear friend!' Athos held him in a long embrace, and the musketeer, who knew his discretion so well, murmured in his ear—'An affair of state,' to which Athos only replied by a pressure of the hand, still more significant. They then separated. Raoul took the arm of his old friend, who led him along the Rue

Saint-Honore. 'I am conducting you to the abode of the god Plutus,' said D'Aragnan to the young man; 'prepare yourself. The whole day you will witness the piling up of crowns. Heavens! how I am changed!'

'Oh! what numbers of people there are in the street!' said Raoul.

'Is there a procession to-day?' asked D'Aragnan of a passer-by.

'Monsieur, it is a hanging,' replied the man.

'What! a hanging at the Grève?' said D'Aragnan.

'Yes, monsieur.'

'The devil take the rogue who gets himself hung the day I want to go and take my rent!' cried D'Aragnan. 'Raoul, did you ever see anybody hung?'

'Never, monsieur—thank God!'

'Oh! how young that sounds! If you were on guard in the trenches, as I was, and a spy! But, pardon me, Raoul, I am doting—you are quite right, it is a hideous sight to see a person hung! At what hour do they hang them, monsieur, if you please?'

'Monsieur,' replied the stranger respectfully, delighted at joining conversation with two men of the sword, 'it will take place at about three o'clock.'

'Aha! it is now only half-past one; let us step out, we shall be there in time to touch my three hundred and seventy-five livres, and get away before the arrival of the malefactor.'

'Malefactors, monsieur,' continued the bourgeois; 'there are two of them.'

'Monsieur, I return to you many thanks,' said D'Aragnan, who as he grew older, had become polite to a degree. Drawing Raoul along, he directed his course rapidly in the direction of La Grève. Without that great experience musketeers have of a crowd, to which were joined an irresistible strength of wrist, and an uncommon suppleness of shoulders, our two travellers would not have arrived at their place of destination. They followed the line of the Quai, which they had gained on quitting the Rue Saint-Honore, where they left Athos. D'Aragnan went first; his elbow, his wrist, his shoulder formed three wedges which he knew how to insinuate with skill into the groups, to make them split and separate like firewood. He made use sometimes of the hilt of his sword as an additional help: introducing it between ribs that were too rebellious, making it take the part of a lever or crowbar, to separate husband from wife, uncle from nephew, and brother from brother. And all that was done so naturally, and with such gracious smiles, that people must have had

unfortunate of men, and you will have said, I love you, to the most illustrious, the most delighted, the most triumphant of the happy beings of this world.'

He was still at her feet, kissing her hand, when Pelisson entered precipitately, crying, in very ill-humour, 'Monseigneur! madame! for Heaven's sake! excuse me. Monseigneur, you have been here half an hour. Oh! do not both look at me so reproachfully. Madame, pray who is that lady who left your house soon after monseigneur came in?'

'Madame Vanel,' said Fouquet.

'Ha!' cried Pelisson, 'I was sure of that.'

'Well! what then?'

'Why, she got into her carriage, looking deadly pale.'

'What consequence is that to me?'

'Yes, but what she said to her coachman is of consequence to you.'

'Kind heaven!' cried the marquise, 'what was that?'

'To M. Colbert's!' said Pelisson, in a hoarse voice.

'Bon Dieu!—begone, begone, monseigneur!' replied the marquise, pushing Fouquet out of the salon, whilst Pelisson dragged him by the hand.

'Am I, then, indeed,' said the superintendent, 'become a child, to be frightened by a shadow?'

'You are a giant,' said the marquise, 'whom a viper is trying to bite in the heel.'

Pelisson continued to drag Fouquet to the carriage. 'To the Palais at full speed!' cried Pelisson to the coachman. The horses set off like lightning; no obstacle relaxed their pace for an instant. Only, at the arcade Saint-Jean, as they were coming out upon the Place de Grève, a long file of horsemen, barring the narrow passage, stopped the carriage of the superintendent. There was no means of forcing this barrier; it was necessary to wait till the mounted archers of the watch, for it was they who stopped the way, had passed with the heavy carriage they were escorting, and which ascended rapidly towards the Place Baudoyer. Fouquet and Pelisson took no further account of this circumstance beyond deploring the minute's delay they had thus to submit to. They entered the habitation of the concierge du Palais five minutes after. That officer was still walking about in the front court. At the name of Fouquet, whispered in his ear by Pelisson, the governor eagerly approached the carriage, and, hat in

on his knees, without saying a word. 'I expected you,' said the marquise, with a tender sigh.

'Oh! no,' cried he, 'or you would have sent away that woman.'

'She has been here little more than half an hour, and I had no expectation she would come this evening.'

'You love me just a little, then, marquise?'

'That is not the question now; it is of your danger; how are your affairs going on?'

'I am going this evening to get my friends out of the prisons of the Palais.'

'How will you do that?'

'By buying and bribing the governor.'

'He is a friend of mine; can I assist you, without injuring you?'

'Oh! marquise, it would be a signal service; but how can you be employed without your being compromised? Now, never shall my life, my power, or even my liberty, be purchased at the expense of a single tear from your eyes, or of one frown of pain upon your brow.'

'Monseigneur, no more such words, they bewilder me; I have been culpable in trying to serve you, without calculating the extent of what I was doing. I love you in reality, as a tender friend; and as a friend, I am grateful for your delicate attentions—but, alas! you will never find a mistress in me.'

'Marquise!' cried Fouquet, in a tone of despair; 'why not?'

'Because you are too much beloved,' said the young woman, in a low voice; 'because you are too much beloved by too many people—because the splendor of glory and fortune wound my eyes, whilst the darkness of sorrow attracts them; because, in short, I, who have repulsed you in your proud magnificence; I who scarcely looked at you in your splendor, I came, like a mad woman, to throw myself, as it were, into your arms, when I saw a misfortune hovering over your head. You understand me now, monseigneur? Become happy again, that I may remain chaste in heart and in thought: your misfortune entails my ruin.'

'Oh! madame,' said Fouquet, with an emotion he had never before felt; 'were I to fall to the lowest degree of human misery, and hear from your mouth that word which you now refuse me, that day, madame, you will be mistaken in your noble egotism; that day you will fancy you are consoling the most

ribs of bronze not to cry thank you when the wrist made its play, or hearts of diamond not to be enchanted when such a bland smile enlivened the lips of the musketeer. Raoul, following his friend, cajoled the women who admired his beauty, pushed back the men who felt the rigidity of his muscles, and both opened, thanks to these manoeuvres, the compact and muddy tide of the populace. They arrived in sight of the two gibbets, from which Raoul turned away his eyes in disgust. As for D'Arragnan, he did not even see them; his house with its gabled roof, its windows crowded with the curious, attracted and even absorbed all the attention he was capable of. He distinguished in the Place and around the houses a good number of musketeers on leave, who, some with women, others with friends, awaited the crowning ceremony. What rejoiced him above all was to see that his tenant, the cabaretier, was so busy he hardly knew which way to turn. Three lads could not supply the drinkers. They filled the shop, the chambers, and the court, even. D'Arragnan called Raoul's attention to this concourse, adding: 'The fellow will have no excuse for not paying his rent. Look at those drinkers, Raoul, one would say they were jolly companions. Mordieux! why, there is no room anywhere?' D'Arragnan, however, contrived to catch hold of the master by the corner of his apron, and to make himself known to him.

'Ah, monsieur le chevalier,' said the cabaretier, half distracted, 'one minute if you please. I have here a hundred mad devils turning my cellar upside down.'

'The cellar, if you like, but not the money-box.'

'Oh, monsieur, your thirty-seven and a half pistoles are all counted out ready for you, upstairs in my chamber; but there are in that chamber thirty customers, who are sucking the staves of a little barrel of Oporto which I tapped for them this very morning. Give me a minute,—only a minute?'

'So be it; so be it.'

'I will go,' said Raoul, in a low voice, to D'Arragnan; 'this hilarity is vile!'

'Monsieur,' replied D'Arragnan, sternly, 'you will please to remain where you are. The soldier ought to familiarize himself with all kinds of spectacles. There are in the eye, when it is young, fibres which we must learn how to harden; and we are not truly generous and good save from the moment when the eye has become hardened, and the heart remains tender. Besides, my little Raoul, would you leave me alone here? That would be very wrong of you.'

Look, there is yonder in the lower court a tree, and under the shade of that tree we shall breathe more freely than in this hot atmosphere of spilt wine.'

From the spot on which they had placed themselves the two new guests of the Image-de-Notre-Dame heard the ever-increasing hubbub of the tide of people, and lost neither a cry nor a gesture of the drinkers, at tables in the cabaret, or disseminated in the chambers. If D'Artagnan had wished to place himself as a vidette for an expedition, he could not have succeeded better. The tree under which he and Raoul were seated covered them with its already thick foliage; it was a low, thick chestnut-tree, with inclined branches, that cast their shade over a table so dilapidated the drinkers had abandoned it. We said that from this post D'Artagnan saw everything. He observed the goings and comings of the waiters; the arrival of fresh drinkers; the welcome, sometimes friendly, sometimes hostile, given to the newcomers by others already installed. He observed all this to amuse himself, for the thirty-seven and a half pistoles were a long time coming. Raoul recalled his attention to it. 'Monsieur,' said he, 'you do not hurry your tenant, and the condemned will soon be here. There will then be such a press we shall not be able to get out.'

'You are right,' said the musketeer; 'Hola! oh! somebody there! Mordieux!' But it was in vain he cried and knocked upon the wreck of the old table, which fell to pieces beneath his fist; nobody came. D'Artagnan was preparing to go and seek the cabaretier himself, to force him to a definite explanation, when the door of the court in which he was with Raoul, a door which communicated with the garden situated at the back, opened, and a man dressed as a cavalier, with his sword in the sheath, but not at his belt, crossed the court without closing the door; and having cast an oblique glance at D'Artagnan and his companion, directed his course towards the cabaret itself, looking about in all directions with his eyes capable of piercing walls of consciences. 'Humph!' said D'Artagnan, 'my tenants are communicating. That, no doubt, now, is some amateur in hanging matters.' At the same moment the cries and disturbance in the upper chambers ceased. Silence, under such circumstances, surprises more than a twofold increase of noise. D'Artagnan wished to see what was the cause of this sudden silence. He then perceived that this man, dressed as a cavalier, had just entered the principal chamber, and was haranguing the tipplers, who all listened to him with the greatest attention. D'Artagnan would perhaps have heard his speech but for the dominant noise of the popular clamours,

'Nothing, alas! and it is that which causes my despair. Nothing, absolutely nothing. Why can I not, on the contrary, say ill enough of her to prevent your going to her?'

But Fouquet had already given orders to stop, and the carriage was motionless. 'Prevent me!' cried Fouquet; 'why, no power on earth should prevent my going to pay my compliments to Madame de Plessis-Belliere; besides, who knows that we shall not stand in need of her!'

'No, monseigneur, no!'

'But I do not wish you to wait for me, Pelisson,' replied Fouquet, sincerely courteous.

'The more reason I should, monseigneur; knowing that you are keeping me waiting, you will, perhaps, stay a shorter time. Take care! You see there is a carriage in the courtyard: she has some one with her.' Fouquet leaned towards the steps of the carriage. 'One word more,' cried Pelisson; 'do not go to this lady till you have been to the concierge, for Heaven's sake!'

'Eh! five minutes, Pelisson,' replied Fouquet, alighting at the steps of the hotel, leaving Pelisson in the carriage, in a very ill-humour. Fouquet ran upstairs, told his name to the footman, which excited an eagerness and a respect that showed the habit the mistress of the house had of honouring that name in her family. 'Monsieur le surintendant,' cried the marquise, advancing, very pale, to meet him; 'what an honour! what an unexpected pleasure!' said she. Then, in a low voice, 'Take care!' added the marquise, 'Marguerite Vanel is here!'

'Madame,' replied Fouquet, rather agitated, 'I came on business. One single word, and quickly, if you please!' And he entered the salon. Madame Vanel had risen, paler, more livid, than Envy herself. Fouquet in vain addressed her, with the most agreeable, most pacific salutation; she only replied by a terrible glance darted at the marquise and Fouquet. This keen glance of a jealous woman is a stiletto which pierces every cuirass; Marguerite Vanel plunged it straight into the hearts of the two confidants. She made a courtesy to her friend, a more profound one to Fouquet, and took leave, under pretense of having a number of visits to make, without the marquise trying to prevent her, or Fouquet, a prey to anxiety, thinking further about her. She was scarcely out of the room, and Fouquet left alone with the marquise, before he threw himself

infuses into the heart. 'Oh! I know a woman who will enact the personage we stand in need of, with the lieutenant-governor of the concierge.'

'And, on my part, I know fifty, monseigneur; fifty trumpets, which will inform the universe of your generosity, of your devotion to your friends, and, consequently, will ruin you sooner or later in ruining themselves.'

'I do not speak of such women. Pelisson; I speak of a noble and beautiful creature who joins to the intelligence and wit of her sex the valor and coolness of ours; I speak of a woman, handsome enough to make the walls of a prison bow down to salute her, discreet enough to let no one suspect by whom she has been sent.'

'A treasure!' said Pelisson; 'you would make a famous present to monsieur the governor of the concierge! Peste! monseigneur, he might have his head cut off; but he would, before dying, have had such happiness as no man had enjoyed before him.'

'And I add,' said Fouquet, 'that the concierge of the Palais would not have his head cut off, for he would receive of me my horses, to effect his escape, and five hundred thousand livres wherewith to live comfortably in England: I add, that this lady, my friend, would give him nothing but the horses and the money. Let us go and seek her, Pelisson.'

The superintendent reached forth his hand towards the golden and silken cord placed in the interior of his carriage, but Pelisson stopped him. 'Monseigneur,' said he, 'you are going to lose as much time in seeking this lady as Columbus took to discover the new world. Now, we have but two hours in which we can possibly succeed; the concierge once gone to bed, how shall we get at him without making a disturbance? When daylight dawns, how can we conceal our proceedings? Go, go yourself, monseigneur, and do not seek either woman or angel to-night.'

'But, my dear Pelisson, here we are before her door.'

'What! before the angel's door?'

'Why, yes.'

'This is the hotel of Madame de Belliere!'

'Hush!'

'Ah! Good Lord!' exclaimed Pelisson.

'What have you to say against her?'

which made a formidable accompaniment to the harangue of the orator. But it was soon finished, and all the people the cabaret contained came out, one after the other, in little groups, so that there only remained six in the chamber; one of these six, the man with the sword, took the cabaretier aside, engaging him in discourse more or less serious, whilst the others lit a great fire in the chimney-place—a circumstance rendered strange by the fine weather and the heat.

'It is very singular,' said D'Arragnan to Raoul, 'but I think I know those faces yonder.'

'Don't you think you can smell the smoke here?' said Raoul.

'I rather think I can smell a conspiracy,' replied D'Arragnan.

He had not finished speaking, when four of these men came down into the court, and without the appearance of any bad design, mounted guard at the door of communication, casting, at intervals, glances at D'Arragnan, which signified many things.

'Mordious!' said D'Arragnan, in a low voice, 'there is something going on. Are you curious, Raoul?'

'According to the subject, chevalier.'

'Well, I am as curious as an old woman. Come a little more in front; we shall get a better view of the place. I would lay a wager that view will be something curious.'

'But you know, monsieur le chevalier, that I am not willing to become a passive and indifferent spectator of the death of the two poor devils.'

'And I, then—do you think I am a savage? We will go in again, when it is time to do so. Come along!' And they made their way towards the front of the house, and placed themselves near the window which, still more strangely than the rest, remained unoccupied. The two last drinkers, instead of looking out at this window, kept up the fire. On seeing D'Arragnan and his friend enter:—'Ah! ah! a reinforcement,' murmured they.

D'Arragnan jogged Raoul's elbow. 'Yes, my braves, a reinforcement,' said he; 'c'est-à-dire there is a famous fire. Whom are you going to cook?'

The two men uttered a shout of jovial laughter, and, instead of answering, threw on more wood. D'Arragnan could not take his eyes off them.

'I suppose,' said one of the fire-makers, 'they sent you to tell us the time—did not they?'

‘Without doubt they have,’ said D’Artagnan, anxious to know what was going on; ‘why should I be here else, if it were not for that?’

‘Then place yourself at the window, if you please, and observe.’ D’Artagnan smiled in his moustache, made a sign to Raoul, and placed himself at the window.

Chapter LIX

A Quarter of an Hour’s Delay



FOUQUET, on leaving his house for the second time that day, felt himself less heavy and less disturbed than might have been expected. He turned towards Pelisson, who was meditating in the corner of the carriage some good arguments against the violent proceedings of Colbert.

‘My dear Pelisson,’ said Fouquet, ‘it is a great pity you are not a woman.’

‘I think, on the contrary, it is very fortunate,’ replied Pelisson, ‘for, monseigneur, I am excessively ugly.’

‘Pelisson! Pelisson!’ said the superintendent, laughing: ‘You repeat too often, you are “ugly”, not to leave people to believe that it gives you much pain.’

‘In fact it does, monseigneur, much pain; there is no man more unfortunate than I: I was handsome, the small-pox rendered me hideous; I am deprived of a great means of attraction; now, I am your principal clerk, or something of that sort; I take great interest in your affairs, and if, at this moment, I were a pretty woman, I could render you an important service.’

‘What?’

‘I would go and find the concierge of the Palais. I would seduce him, for he is a gallant man, extravagantly partial to women; then I would get away our two prisoners.’

‘I hope to be able to do so myself, although I am not a pretty woman,’ replied Fouquet.

‘Granted, monseigneur; but you are compromising yourself very much.’

‘Oh!’ cried Fouquet, suddenly, with one of those secret transports which the generous blood of youth, or the remembrance of some sweet emotion,